THE DOG RESCUE INTERFACE- ADVOCACY ONLINE

EDUCATION

OVERVIEW

1. The USA's dog crisis.

Our country is having a dog crisis nationwide. Dogs have been overbred, abandoned, exploited and harmed for a long time by the worst of human beings. Learn about illegal breeding and which breeds are suffering the consequences; Learn about exploitation of dogs and how these illegal systems operate nationwide; Learn about dog abuse and neglect, and how it negatively impacts a dog's behavior and chances for adoption or re-homing at the expense of emotional damage and breed stereotyping; Learn about dog abandonment statistics, how it places strain on our stray population and the rescue organizations.

2. The rescue process.

Everything you need to know about the rescue process- from shelter, to foster, to adoption. Review **The Decompression Protocol** and its *key concepts* pages 9-11.

3. Learn about Euthanasia.

Learn about "kill shelters" and how this process works. This is a hard reality that our very important shelter workers and volunteers face every single day.

- *What is euthanasia?*
- *How do dogs get placed on a euthanasia list?*
- *What the community is doing to implement more "no-kill shelters".*
- *Current statistics of dog euthanasia in the USA.*

4. Senior Dogs, Sanctuaries, and Our Vision. What the people can do to help.

Learn all about Senior Dog Sanctuaries, and how they work. Read about our vision for the near future. Review what the public can do to help the dog crisis in order to eliminate more suffering, help those who are suffering, and to keep supporting the dog rescue community.

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5. What rescue partners and shelters need the most to provide optimal care, comfort and networking for dogs in need.

Stay informed on the core needs of rescue partners and shelters, such as veterinary needs, comfort needs, training needs, and feeding needs.



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1. The USA's Dog Crisis

Our country is in a crisis. Our dog population keeps growing due to irresponsible and illegal breeding operations both big and small. Dog adoptions have decreased significantly since 2022, theoretically due to economic and financial reasons that keep rescue groups low funded and potential adopters hesitant. The dog rescue community operates on optimized and supported facilitation of the foster-to-adopt processes, which we will learn about in a few sections. As advocates for dogs in need, we hope that spreading education and awareness of this crisis will provide more functional and productive support to the table as we try to increase adoption rates and provide safe and reliable placements simultaneously. Placing these dogs where they can thrive is our ultimate goal. The right people are out there. We are meant to live in harmony with these dogs. According to the *ASPCA* and annual reports of *Shelter Animals Count*, about 2.8 million dogs were placed in the U.S shelter system in the year of 2025. Approximately 59% of these dogs arrived as strays and 30% were owner-surrendered *(aspca.org*). Thousands of stray dogs were lost and safely reunited to their owners *(aspca.org*). Ultimately, most of these dogs become lost in the system. The growing population overwhelms shelter systems and the way they operate as they operate heavily on volunteer work and little to no funding assistance from the government.

Illegal and **irresponsible breeding operations** occur nationwide for many different reasons, more than likely all related to exploitation. You may ask, how are dogs exploited? What is exploitation anyway? **Exploitation** is the use of a living being for selfish or financial reasons usually leading to inhumane outcomes. Dogs are exploited in the illegal and underground breeding world. The breeding of dogs comes with responsibility for proper veterinary care and humane treatment of the animals, especially with litters of puppies. Even in clean and proper conditions, overbreeding becomes a selfish activity for financial gain that leads to an overpopulation of dogs. It has proven to be a challenge to properly regulate the spaying and neutering of dogs in the case of unlicensed breeders offering little to no education or resources to adopters. Not all breeders vet their adoption applicants properly or with the best intentions. Placing dogs in the correct home best for their individualized needs is crucial to successful adoptions, especially considering the fact that failed adoptions play a key role in this crisis right in front of us. Shelter workers and rescue coordinators are privy to the reality sufficient vetting can do and does for successful or non-successful adoptions. Workers of the rescue community do what they do out of passion for animal welfare. This is a different kind of business and culture, where dogs will not be viewed as objects with a price. Included with proper vetting is reputable references including veterinary reference if other pets are owned to ensure that the dogs vital needs are going to be met efficiently. Personal references can also tell us a lot about how reliable this potential adopter is – are they going to give up on this dog if things get "tough"? Are they prepared and willing to work their lives around a new member of the family? These types of questions are important as we navigate to avoid failed adoptions, such as adopting a dog out to

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someone who will return the dog back to the shelter, or even worse, leave on the side of the road or tied up to a fence. Shelter workers can provide adopters with many different resources for affordable veterinary cares, spay and neutering and even training. **Overbreeding** occurs when breeders overbreed their dogs. This negatively impacts the health of the puppy litters, and mother in most cases. It is a cause of suffering that can be avoided. Aside from the immense mental suffering and various different health concerns of mother and puppies, it contributes to overcrowded shelters. Once the reality of these shelters is seen, breeding for sales will seem irresponsible during a time like this.

Besides breeding irresponsibly or for sales, there are people who illegally breed for underground dog fighting rings. This operation flies under the radar most of the time until a complaint is made; and even then, so many dogs have suffered at the hands of such a business, as well as become permanently injured or strayed. **Dog Fighting** is an illegal sport for entertainment, where dogs are forced to fight each other for a show. Many times, this type of illegal event involves gamboling and other illegal activities underground. These dogs are kept in poor conditions, lack veterinary care, and lack what it feels like to be loved. Due to persistently abusive treatment, these dogs either succumb to the suffering or remain victim of fight or flight mode for the rest of their lives without therapy and training. This is heart breaking to anyone who values animal welfare. Dogfighting networks continue to operate despite recent exposure and federal arrests. According to *CNN*, "Dog fighting is an illegal blood sport where dogs are forced to fight inside an enclosure (or "pit") for spectator entertainment and gambling profits. While it is a felony in all 50 U.S states and a federal crime, a highly organized underground network continues to operate globally" (*'Inside the Underground World of Dogfighting: How the Brutal Blood Sport Thrives in The Shadows, Chapman, 2026*). This article shares a story about a recent dogfighting ring bust in Columbia, South Carolina. Federal agents saved nearly 40 pitbulls from this operation, most of which exhibited signs of abuse. After this seizure, the pitbulls go to a shelter where many will require diligent training and decompression before being listed as adoptable. This example is among many- for perspective, according to the ASPCA, there are about 40,000 professional and non-professional participants active in dogfighting, with street level participants climbing up to 100,000. The ASPCA has directly helped with over 300 targeted cases of dogfighting across at least 24 states (*'Dogfighting', ASPCA.org*). The awareness of this brutal reality is important to spread, as it is up to the public to report any suspicions of such an activity. Otherwise, too many of these operations will continue to thrive on. The 'Dogfighting' article shares a clear and precise overview of Michael Vicks case which made the public eye in April 2007. "The April 2007 arrests of National Football League quarterback Michael Vick and his associates exposed the brutal reality of dogfighting to the American public. The ASPCA aided the investigation of Vick's Bad Newz kennels in Virgina, where our forensic veterinarians helped analyze and collect evidence, including 51 living and nine dead dogs" (*'Dogfighting', ASPCA.org*). Based on federal law reforms, key changes were implemented immediately following the 2007 Michael Vicks dog fighting ring bust, such as the **Animal Fighting Prohibition Enforcement Act** (2007), which changed the charges for involvement in dog fighting from a misdemeanor to a federal felony. It also is responsible for banning

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commerce businesses that sell dog fighting items such as slashers. A more recent legislation implemented in 2014 known as the **Animal Fighting Spectator Prohibition Act** (2014) targets any individual involved as a spectator, especially for gambling purposes at dog fighting events; making it a federal crime to attend these events. Dog fighting events heavily rely on the money these spectators put down, which counts for involvement and results in a felony charge with possible time in jail depending on the case. According to an STLPR article by Kelly Moffitt, “Of the 53 dogs rescued from Vick’s fighting ring, most of them went to the Best Friends Animal Society in Utah for rehabilitation… The dogs had experienced unconscionable brutality in the fighting ring and where they were held captive. Some of the pitbulls were electrocuted and others had their backs broken... all in an effort to encourage them to fight” (*Moffitt, 2015)*. The article published on November 4, 2015 proceeds to highlight the good news that these dogs received recovery at a sanctuary, which reiterates the importance of recovery from abuse and neglect, especially the fact that it is possible to recover these dogs if the resources are available. It also continues to highlight the reality of breed perceptions as they are based on a lot of misinformation and even myths. Moffitt’s article shares some eye-opening statements on breed stereotyping by Ledy Vankavage, a senior legislative attorney with Best Friends Animal Society. “Population and the use of pitbulls in fighting rings amped up popular perception that pitbulls are a ‘dangerous breed’, leading to breed-discriminatory laws across the United States that prohibit owning a certain breed of dog in particular municipalities” (*Moffitt*, 2015.) “’They’re outdated laws that need to be changed’, said VanKavage. ‘The research shows these laws are ineffective. They fail to enhance public safety and they interfere with property rights. As a responsible dog owner, you should be able to own any breed that you choose’” (*Moffitt, 2015*). VanKavage declares that dog related violence is a direct result of the treatment of the dog, rather than the breed. Ledy VanKavage had owned a rescued pitbull herself, and remains very knowledgeable on dog behavior and how to properly and easily diffuse a situation that could result in a dog bite. Moving onward, we want to reestablish the importance behind careful handling with a dog that has previously been abused or neglected. Slow introductions to new people and other animals are crucial when you have adopted a dog that knows abuse as they can hold anxiety and PTSD just as we can. Also, just as us, therapy and decompression in the right environment can produce a successful recovery. **Abuse and neglect** teach a dog that they must remain in a “fight-or-flight” response. Dogs are individuals with their own personalities, too. These fears can manifest in different ways, such as shyness and cowering, or reactiveness and aggression when feeling cornered. Again, this is why decompression protocol is so important for dogs that have suffered. Dogs that have suffered neglect or multiple rehoming experiences will many times result in the dog “shutting down”. This is a time where time and patience are key, and the new owners are needed more than ever to not give up on the dog. They will come to you when they are ready as soon as they know that they are not going to be abandoned again. This is why education is so important to the cause: There are many failed adoptions and foster plans due to lack of knowledge behind decompression protocol and not only properly handling the behaviors of different breeds, but also the behaviors that result from traumatic experiences such as abuse, neglect and

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rehoming. See next section to learn about the Decompression Protocol, which was implemented as a crucial part of the rescue process developed by shelter workers and foster partners in the communities.

2. The Rescue Process

We all know that dogs are first rescued from their immediately dangerous situation, which is an initial win. However, this is just the beginning of a long road to rescue and recovery. Whether a dog has been rehomed three times and has spent close to a year in a foster atmosphere, or a dog has just been rescued to the pound from being tied up and abandoned in a city park, there is a process the rescue community adheres to, and we cannot stress enough that these dogs are never truly rescued until they are safe at a no-kill sanctuary or in their forever home. But we will take each win along the way with gratitude and optimism. This is why donations and fundraising are so important, as it helps shelter workers and rescue groups provide the best quality care and attention to dogs that are technically rescued but are still at risk for deteriorating in a stressful and unsettled life. We have a clear and concise breakdown of the rescue process so that you know exactly how it works:

1. ANIMAL CONTROL AND THE LOCAL POUND

The dog is saved by animal control and is out of immediate danger. They will have food and shelter; however, this is the first step to being completely safe. Animal control officers work tirelessly to handle and care for these dogs at their absolute worst point in trauma and behaviors. Nine times out of ten the dogs are still very frightened, uncomfortable and distrusting of humans at this point depending on the situation that came before the pound. At the pound or municipal shelter, this is where networking can typically begin. Many rescue groups and advocates visit these locations to help socialize these dogs and get them seen through networking. They will assist in walking the dogs, passing on information of each dog to rescue shelters and potential adopters the best they can. Many dogs are evaluated here for their behavior and will have some training so that adopters could have as much information on the dog as possible to have the most successful experience. Some dogs are rescue only, meaning a rescue group will have to pull them to their shelter for further training, decompression and evaluation before being publicly adoptable. It works this way so that a dog who may have certain behavioral tendencies could have a little more time to get out of survival mode; and the rescue group is its safety net. Publicly

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adoptable dogs can be adopted upfront from the pound in most cases. Many resources will be offered to an adopter here; such as information on cost-friendly spay and neutering, contact information for trainers, and even cost-friendly vaccinations. The thing about this community, is that there is plenty of help. We want things to always work out. And we want to encourage responsible, dedicated and kind-hearted people to consider adopting pets over shopping for pets. This gets controversial as breeders also have many dogs deserving of homes too. However, we are overpopulated with dogs in the shelter systems, and breeders at the end of the day are more than likely equipped to foster out the dogs that they have. We hope to reduce the number of breeders for sales until we gain some control over the crisis right in front of us. We hope to completely eliminate irresponsible breeders. **Once the dogs are with animal control**, the next big priority is to have them rescued – preferably to a non-kill shelter. Unfortunately, our country still has many shelters that do euthanasia, which we will get into detail about in a later section. But Euthanasia is a humane yet heartbreaking reality where dogs that are being overlooked at over-crowded shelters are put to sleep by a veterinarian. Dogs that may have costly health issues or who are shutting down and withdrawing from shelter stress, or who are simply just running out of time where the shelter needs to make space for new intakes. **Dogs can be saved from the Euthanasia list.** This is where rescue comes in, and this is also how the public (you) and all dog lovers can help, on social media- sharing these dogs' stories, contacting or even tagging local rescue groups and sanctuaries, and reaching out to anyone you know who is interested in adopting a dog. **Best case scenario,** a dog gets rescued. He/she then is brought to whichever shelter has rescued the dog.

2. THE SHELTER

The dog gets to the shelter. Rescue groups work side by side with shelter systems and most actually have their own shelter. This environment remains a bit over stimulating and loud with barking, however it's the next step to safety. The dog can get further attention, care and recovery- especially if it is a rehab-based rescue organization. Many dogs do have an injury or medical condition that need treated, such as heart worm positive. The shelter will more than likely be treating them and they will be upfront on the dog's adoption card. Shelter workers show up for these dogs every single day. Here, the main goals are to get these dogs exposed to the public. We want the right people to see these dogs and hear their stories. From the shelter, we really hope to get these dogs adopted, or at least saved by a foster. Further networking occurs to make this happen. In the meantime, the dogs at shelters will be cared for, fed, socialized, walked, played with. However, shelter stress occurs with a lot of dogs. It is when the noise and constant activity around them begins to take a physical and mental toll. It is very sad to watch, as shelter workers still have to worry about maintaining space for new intakes.

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3. FOSTERS

A foster is a temporary or long-term caregiver who opens their home to a dog in need (i.e. waiting to be adopted); and in more cases, foster homes take in multiple dogs. The dog(s) will have a nice home environment, can decompress, and begin to adhere to a routine which is so important for dogs and their nervous systems. Fosters can even have the option to adopt after a certain period of time. All of this information can be given to you if you sign up to be a foster. We like to encourage anyone who has the interest, the space, the time, the compassion, and the patience, to please look into signing up to be a foster. Someone can even do a one-time short-term foster for an adopter who needs 1 month to prepare for their new dog. Fostering can solve many problems when obstacles are in the way of a successful adoption. It gives a dog more time to be seen, and it can help adopters in other difficult situations. For example, someone is very interested in a dog who has run out of time at a shelter, but they are in the middle of moving homes, and will need a whole month before they can actually pick up the dog. Finding a foster for this dog in particular is very important, upon some agreements. A rescue group can pull this dog from the shelter and to an agreeable foster home for 1 month so that the adopter can save this dog (if the adopter is deemed fit for the dog in particular and application has been processed). Foster communities are a very crucial part to this entire process, and networking with them is the foundation to keeping dogs in need alive and well. Do you think you would be interested in fostering? Fosters are usually financially supported with whatever they need for the dogs in their care. You will provide temporary care, food and training, with a safe space for the dog until he/she finds a permanent home. **Visit our websites homepage**, and use our **search** engine to find your **local shelters and rescue groups**. Contact them via email or phone number to let them know you are interested in becoming a foster, and they will assist you accordingly by having you apply.

4. ADOPTION PROCESS

The dog has some interests. The dog lived in a home of domestic violence previously. He lived with 2 other small dogs. He was kept outside most of the time on a short leash, and eventually was abandoned in a public park – outside in the cold. The best home for this dog would be one without children as his behavioral intake states some food guarding, anxiety, and reactivity towards crowds of people. This dog is a 72 lb. puppy. A few applicants pass the vetting process. Each applicant has received a phone call where they are briefly interviewed. The application requires a veterinary reference and/or personal references to ensure the dog is going to a good home. The references have all given great reviews; however, one stood out the most. This applicant currently has one small dog who is also neutered, no children in the home, impeccable records from veterinarian, and a large fenced in backyard. This is the

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one. This dog is going home to this adopter. The adopter and the shelter arrange a date and time for a meet and greet. It goes really well. The dog can go home with her. She will be instructed on crate training, pointers on leash training, and she'll be given resources to contact trainers if needed. She will also be given resources for cost friendly vet care, spay/neutering. She also has a full story on what this dog has gone through. She is aware that this dog may feel protective of her once he trusts her. She will be very careful with slow introductions to other people, especially if a boyfriend enters the picture. She is agreeable to this. She is fully invested in her new companion. Most rescue groups will stay in contact with new adopters for immediate advice and guidance. This is a huge win. This dog was saved, and now gets to go home. From here, we ensure the adopter has as much education and resources as possible to ensure that this adoption is successful. Unfortunately, there are failed adoptions. Some people bring their dog back to the shelter because "they are too big" or "they are too wild". This is why the **Decompression Protocol** is so important. This is why patience and time is so important. These dogs need time to heal emotionally, mentally, physically- and most importantly, they need time to gain trust in their surroundings and new owner(s). SEE BELOW:

DOG DECOMPRESSION PROTOCOL IS A PERIOD MEANT FOR LOW STIMULATION FOR THE DOG TO BEGIN TO FEEL SAFE IN THEIR NEW ENVIRONMENT.

The Decompression protocol was formulated by members of the rescue community- shelter workers, and highly reputable trainers with the inputs of dog behavioral specialists. The Decompression Protocol is a step-by-step guide in which new dog owners, adopters, and fosters can access for successful integration into a new life, routine and home. We have found a very helpful resource (listed under resources at the end of this educational packet) that features everything and anything you would need to know about decompression as well as the protocol itself- explained in a user-friendly fashion. *Sniff Spot* is a wonderful organization whose website shares the complete guide, educational viewpoints such as the 2-week shutdown and how to support a dog during decompression, frequently asked questions, and additional helpful resources for everyone to access. Let us note that decompression protocol is smart to do in any situation or circumstance involving a new dog or puppy, whether the dog or puppy was rescued from a shelter, directly from a foster home, or from a breeder. PROTOCOL NEXT PAGE:

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The Decompression Stages: The 3-3-3 Rule

A) The first 3 days

Within the first 3 days of your new dog being home, he or she will exhibit signs of fearfulness, worry, confusion, and even timid behavior. They may be very quiet and appear “shut down”, or they may be anxious and reactive. Reactivity refers to overreacting to certain stimulations and triggers that would normally illicit a much less stressful response (i.e. erratic barking when strangers are near, anxious running and barking when other animals are seen, or any type of aggression towards physical movement in and around their personal space). It is normal for a do to bark at the neighbors once in a while. A dog in reactive mode would be inconsolable and possible exhibit a panicked response, and could be trained by controlling the exposure the dog has to outside factors and offering the dog a safe space in the home to calm down when needed. During these first 3 days, these dogs are surviving. They are not in any way reflecting their actual personalities just yet, as they are slowly gaining trust from those around them as well as from their environment. Therefore, during this stage, maintain low stimulation in the home, wherever you are giving your dog his/her personal space. For example, if being kennel trained (which is highly recommended, see Kennel training resource at Karen Pryor Academy's Positive Crate Training Guide. **It is recommended** during at least the first 3 days to a week to keep everything calm, no visitors, limited short outings, and no forceful interactions. Allow the dog to approach others before physically contacting them on your terms. According to *Sniff Spot*, some dogs will eat and drink as normal during this period; however, “Others won’t eat for the first day or two”. This is actually normal, and a dog should never be force-fed. If the dog continues to not eat, contact your veterinarian for guidance. Offer your dog a safe space of their own with limited noise, some new toys, fresh water and food. Time outdoors is important, but keep the outdoor for potty breaks for now. Use a loop leash for easy maneuvering without getting too physical with the dog at this time, depending on their behavior when you reach over to them. Playing white noise on the tv or YouTube as well as relaxing music at a low volume could also be helpful if the puppy or dog is being hyper or distracted.

B) The first 3 weeks

Within the first 3 weeks of bringing your new dog home, the dog’s personality will begin to peek through. Depending on the dog’s history (whether he/she came from an abusive home, neglectful situation, from a home of domestic violence, from the street, or from a long stay at a shelter), his or her personality may show in increments and in a different time frame. Within the first 3 weeks, the dog is slowly understanding his/her routine and the routine of the household. Many dogs will test their rules during this time also, as well as exhibit pieces of their personality or current behavior that were not yet evident, such as “resource

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guarding, persistent reactivity, separation anxiety, or the beginning of genuine playfulness and attachment" (*Sniff Spot*). During this period, it is important to remain patient and as flexible as possible, so that the dog can finally trust some consistency around him or her. It is also **crucial** to note, that during this 3-week phase of the protocol, it is unfortunately common for a lot of people to assume that the hardest part has passed, and that the dog is completely healed. "This is also when owners often make the mistake of assuming the hard part is over and start introducing the dog to everything at once: dog parks, playdates, neighborhood walks, visitors. The dog may seem ready. They often aren't" (*Sniff Spot*).

C) The first 3 months

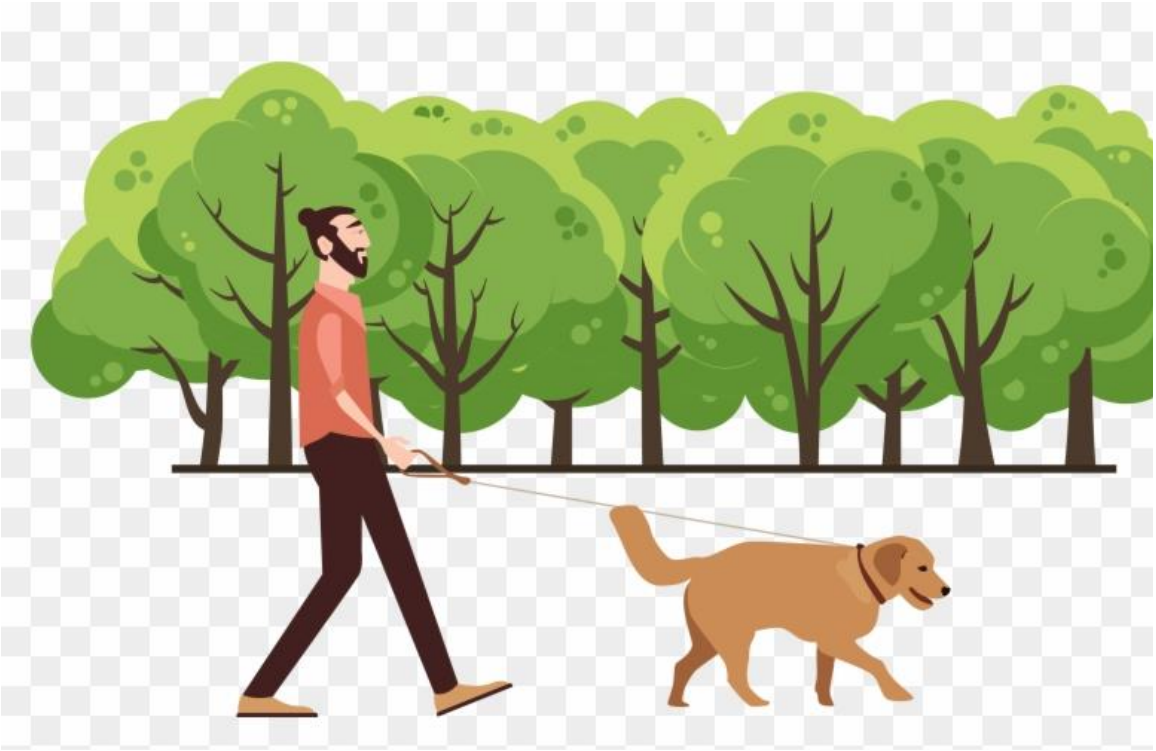
Most dogs are finally settled into their new home and routines by 3 months. They continue to show you who they really are, and they are also trusting their new people now. This is the best time for official training such as potty training and learning commands, as the dog is out of fight-or-flight mode and training will be most effective. Sniff Spot informs us that some dogs such as seniors and dogs that came from abusive situations may take longer than 3 months to fully adapt. Some may always need some separation from other animals or strangers, which are details that are always shared between the rescue group/shelter and the potential adopter straight for the beginning. Sniff Spot not only has shared such meaningful education with the online community, they run an organization where dog owners can book a lovely and safely gated in yard or outdoors property to bring your dog, without the worry of too many other people being around. It is a fantastic organization that basically compares to having a private dog park for you and your new buddy. This is great for training and bonding with your rescue dog. Again, check out https://www.sniffspot.com .

The 2-Week Shutdown

The 2-week shutdown is recommended for senior dogs, and rescues. It is a more structured version of the Decompression Protocol, with a goal to give these dogs an actually chance to calm their nervous systems down biologically. The main point is to follow the protocol, and also to spend the first 2 weeks maintaining a significantly low stimulated environment. This includes things like no play or introduction to other dogs, no dog parks, no large groups of people or visitors, calm interaction with household members only, and implementing a consistent daily routine. Sniff Spot recommends the same walking times, same feeding times and same bed times. One new thing at a time is also recommended, such as a decompression walk. A decompression walk is a pressure-free and leashed walk where your new dog leads the way with little to no obedience training yet (unless he/she is walking into danger). This is very healthy for the dog to sniff its way around naturally, and go at its own pace, which commonly resets anxiety or reactivity, as well as provides healthy mental enrichment from the sniffing. See Bravo Dog

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Behaviour Decompression Walks . The 2-week shut down is comparable to a longer first “3 day” phase of the decompression protocol, with the gradual addition of introductions and other variables. To conclude, overall, the first 6 months to a year is a time to be patient and open to changes and alterations depending on the dog and how they are responding to their new owners and home.



3. What is Euthanasia? Why does it happen? What are we doing to change this?

Euthanasia is a painless medical procedure that ends a dog’s life for various reasons. This is done by a veterinarian. Some dogs that are suffering with terminal illness’s will be euthanized by the owner’s choice with humane purpose. But most of our dogs nationwide that are euthanized are dogs that are in the shelter system. Euthanasia refers to the intentional ending of life to relieve pain and suffering, according to the Merriam-Webster. The National Institutes of Health (NIH) states that the word **Euthanasia** “comes from the Greek words *eu* (meaning ‘good’) and *Thanatos* (meaning ‘death’), literally translating to a ‘good

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death'. It is also known as 'mercy killing'" (NIH.gov). The concept is heartbreaking, and the dogs story ending here is just devastating. Even though their suffering will end, it is still something that burdens all shelter workers, rescue workers, volunteers and animal control officer's carry. These people see the overcrowded facilities every day. They feel the lack of resources. They feel the confusion and sadness of these dogs every single day. Euthanasia most often occurs to maintain shelter space. When adoption rates are at a low, shelters and pounds get overcrowded. Both sick and perfectly healthy dogs are euthanized everyday nationwide because they have simply run out of time. Of course, there is euthanizing for dogs that have harmed a person with aggressive behavior. This is more of a choice on the owners' parts. More times than not, a dog has a reason for aggression and was more than likely in a situation that was set up for failure in the first place. Dogs at shelters will eventually receive a deadline for adoption chances. Rescues groups and advocacy networks will work tirelessly to get these dogs seen by potential adopters or pulled by a no-kill rescue organization. Sometimes the dogs that are handling shelter life the worst will be placed on the list when space must be made. We believe that no matter what, there is always a better option. But at the same time, municipal shelters need more funding and community support. They need for government support. We need to get more of the pubic involved with making contributions to stray and rescue projects. A lot of charities and fundraising can support more sanctuaries for senior dogs and long-stay shelter dogs. **The dog rescue community is actively working to change things here.** Education, awareness, and involvement on the events and discussions are keys in the solution. See a petition related to the eradication of kill-shelters? Please sign it. Because there are more options. There are groups and organizations who transport many shelter dogs to different areas of the country that have higher adoption rates, and where the dogs in particular may have a better chance at getting adopted, and where there are no-kill shelters. The shelters still struggle with space. But we ultimately want to see the statistics of euthanized healthy dogs decrease completely. **Statistically**, based on annual data from the *ASPCA* and *Shelter Animals Count*, **about 876 dogs are euthanized in animal shelters every day across the United States**. This includes puppies, seniors, healthy dogs, and dogs of all breeds and behaviors. In 2025, an estimated 320,000 shelter dogs were euthanized (*shelteranimalscount.org*). It is simply due to limited resources, limited adopters, and space concerns at the shelters and pounds. Rescue Volunteers across the country express their emotional distress and "feelings of defeat" every single day when the dogs that they've spent time with and time advocating for actually end up getting euthanized. We must support the community here... together.

4. Senior Dogs, Sanctuaries, TDRI Vision, what can you do to help?

Every single dog deserves peace and a chance to live. **The Dog Recue Interface** has a vision for the near future- and it involves more long-term shelter dogs having the opportunity to live in sanctuaries. With proper funding and advocacy, this can absolutely happen in all 50 states. We can make this a very positive thing for everyone. It can offer more jobs for people and more volunteer work opportunities for

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people who love dogs and even for people who need healing themselves. We have this vision of a sanctuary being the last stop. A sanctuary can be on a nice piece of land; depending on what part of the country. It can be set up like a ranch or a well facilitated park with play yard options, sleep kennels, food, activities, and walks – city or countryside. In our vision, the mission for these sanctuaries is to provide long-term living for dogs in need and who cannot find homes. These sanctuaries will be well equipped with space (depending on the location, and various types of staff comparable to a shelters system. Sanctuaries will be the last and final stop for any dogs that are senior (8 years old and over), long-stay shelter dogs who are experiencing kennel stress or medical issues, or any other factors that are leaving the dogs difficult to find an adopter. This is a very big vision, we agree. But we are not the ones that came up with this idea. In fact, we have sanctuaries already. There are many sanctuaries in the Midwest for senior dogs- which is a beautiful thing. It is important to mention or tag these sanctuaries in any post on social media regarding a senior dog on the euthanasia list at a shelter. With proper networking and support, the dog can always be transported. Some examples of rescue transport groups are The ASPCA Relocation Program , which will transport dogs from overcrowded or under-resourced shelters across the nation to places with higher adoption demand and shelters with more space. They will transport by road or flight, which is pretty fantastic on the founders' parts. These programs are wonderful and we want to make sure that they are recognized, supported, and thriving. Some **sanctuaries** that are up and running right now are geared towards providing senior dogs or hospice dogs with long term care in a beautiful place, and we have helped network dogs in need to their locations on Facebook. Whispering Willows Senior Dog Sanctuary, INC. is a non-profit senior and hospice dog sanctuary in Missouri. Click link to be directed to their website where you can learn all about their cause, what they do, their partners, and ways to help and donate. Old Friends Senior Dog Sanctuary is a non-profit sanctuary providing lifelong homing and cares to senior dogs in Mount Juliet, Tennessee. Visit their website to stay involved, view the dogs and their stories, and even to check out their online shop of awesome apparels in which any proceeds go towards their sanctuary funding. Old Friends Senior Dog Sanctuary even shares information on becoming a Geezer Guardian- where you can locally provide companionship by opening you home to a senior dog through Old Friends Forever Foster Program **with full support from Old Friends community.** Per their website:

- "Our primary goal at Old Friends Senior Dog Sanctuary is to find lifelong placements where our old friends can live the remainder of their lives as part of a loving family. Most of the old friends you see at the PAWvillions are looking for their own *Geezer Guardian(s).* While some of our seniors have medical or mobility challenges, many are still full of energy and have a lot of love to give. Through donations, we provide all veterinary care- including prescription food, medications and preventatives- for the dogs living with *Geezer Guardians* for the rest of their lives".
- "Geezer Guardians must live in a 100-mile radius of Mount Juliet, TN, as we require our Old Friends to receive care from our in-house veterinarian."

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- “If you live outside of our 100-mile radius and would like to adopt a senior dog, we encourage you to contact your local shelter as there are senior dogs everywhere in need of loving retirement homes. You may also consider **sponsoring an Old Friend** by clicking “Sponsor” on that Old Friend’s profile page!” (Old Friends website gives you the option to view the profiles of each of their residents, and this is where you can choose to at least sponsor one).

  These are only two examples of sanctuaries in the U.S. We do need more. But these wonderful organizations make it work, and they’ve saved thousands of dogs from having heartbreaking endings. Always do the favor of looking through websites of the dog rescue community. Donate if you can. At least share and spread the word to others; because this is a priority for animal welfare. Let’s undo what bad humans have done to our dogs! Factually, things like medical and care costs, life changes of the owner such as homelessness, moving or death, and economic pressures all contribute to the high rates of surrendered senior dogs. According to national rescue data, a senior dog may spend typically four times as long in shelters as younger dogs. Prospective adopters also tend to lean towards puppies and younger adults out of fear for medical expenses. This is why older dogs are overlooked in their kennels. We want to change this. It is a true blessing and gift to actually get to bring a senior dog into your home, if your circumstances are realistic. There are so many resources that could help with care and costs. **Our last message to close this section- there is a different dog fitting for every single loving family or dog lover. We are meant to harmonize with these precious beings. They heal us in more ways than you could possibly imagine.**
  The people can do many different things to help support our dog rescue community, and most importantly, the dogs themselves. We will reiterate the importance of donations. A one-time donation is always just as appreciated. Every website, every social media page of the shelter or rescue group, will provide user-friendly descriptions and secure options for making donations.
- Donate to a cause. See our websites list of organizations such as nationwide and local charities, rescue missions, companies who donate money to shelters, stray projects and veterinary organizations- that we update frequently.
- Use our TDRI search engine on our homepage to search for local and non-local rescues and shelters; then get on your social media, find their pages, and interact with their posts: follow them, share their stories, advocate, and network their posts of dogs in need to proper rescue groups. Something as simple as interacting with their posts, helps them to gain a lot of attention by the right people and the right help.
- Educate others. Everything that you have learned here, share with others. Print this education packet out. Advise any person who wants to purchase a dog, to ADOPT instead. Educate them on the responsibilities and life-long commitment that comes with owning a dog of any kind.
- Spread awareness. Spread everything that you know to your friends and families. And especially to anybody who is interested in adopting and rescuing a dog in need. Especially to dog lovers.

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- Spread awareness regarding signs of dog abuse. Report suspicions of dog abuse and neglect… please!
- Consider fostering. Consider volunteering at a shelter.
- Consider advocating for your local shelters by networking for them online. Use our search engine to find community discussions and important events.

5. What Does the Rescue Community Need the Most?

In order to positively impact shelters in terms of animal intake, care, adoptions and operational costs, the public can help most by:

- Joining online advocacy and the spreading of awareness
- Financial donations to the shelter (for food, vet costs, transportations, adoption fees, supplies)
- Support by donating supplies and food to particular projects and charities
- Donate to wish lists of dogs in need. Donate care packages to dogs in need through iHeart Dogs e-commerce website.
- Stay active on social media to support the various rescue organizations such as shelters, sanctuaries, humane societies, and more.

Thank you for your time.

With Love,

The Dog Rescue Interface

ADVOCACY ONLINE

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RESOURCES

https://www.sniffspot.com/blog/dog-training/dog-decompression

https://www.aspca.org/helping-shelters-people-pets/us-animal-shelter-statistics

https://www.cnn.com/2023/12/27/us/underground-dog-fighting-seizures-invs

https://www.aspca.org/investigations-rescue/dogfighting

https://www.stlpr.org/show/st-louis-on-the-air/2015-11-04/pit-bulls-and-breed-discriminatory-laws-following-vicks-dog-fighting-conviction-what-has-changed

https://www.shelteranimalscount.org/2025-report

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